

Boston Sunday Globe

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JUNE 7, 2026

In 2021, Martha's Vineyard Hospital ran 78 tests for alpha gal.
In 2024, the number topped 1,600.

About 44 percent were positive.

Unwelcome visitor



Lone star ticks are literally everywhere on Martha's Vineyard. So is the nasty food allergy they transmit.



PHOTOS BY FINN GOMEZ FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Top, homeowner Jon Posner has sprayed with a heavy-duty pesticide. Above, biologist Patrick Roden-Reynolds organized ticks after a survey.

By Jason Laughlin
GLOBE STAFF

AQUINNAH — The white flannel flag twisted and rippled in a gentle ocean breeze as Patrick Roden-Reynolds, Martha's Vineyard's resident tick expert, dragged it along grass and gnarled undergrowth in search of tiny arachnids that have upended life on this island.

The flag acted like Velcro, snagging ticks from their hiding places.

Roden-Reynolds unfurled the flag on the lawn and, after a moment's inspection, pointed out a crab-like arachnid the size of an apple seed scuttling across the white fabric.

"Lone star tick," he said, coolly.

This was one of the scary ones, the relatively new arrivals that spread alpha gal syndrome, an incurable allergy to red meat, dairy, even some medicines found in everyday life across the island.

Martha's Vineyard is famous as a summer playground for presidents and celebrities, but a nearly microscopic menace now haunts the dune grasses, marshlands, lawns, and scrub that cover nearly all this island.

While ticks are nothing new to Martha's Vineyard, alpha gal is, and the fear of contracting it casts a shadow over virtually every aspect of summer fun, from flip-flops to burgers on a grill.

Want to hike safely? Wear long pants tucked into your socks. Not exactly ideal summer wear. Long-time islanders have to be wary of going in their own

TICKS, Page A16

'Superdodgers' are rare but could hold COVID clues

Scientists aim to learn why some resist pathogens

By Sarah Rahal
GLOBE STAFF

More than six years since the pandemic, COVID-19 infections have become a near-universal experience. Most people have tested positive at least once. Many have had it multiple times. And yet, a small, persistent group insists they've never had it at all.

Who are these so-called superdodgers, sometimes dubbed "NOVIDs"? Are they outliers of behavior, beneficiaries of luck, or do they hold clues to something deeper in human biology?

Last month, the Globe asked readers who believe they've never caught the coronavirus to share their experi-

ences.

The response was overwhelming. More than 500 people wrote in, many offering to sign up for clinical trials, convinced their stories might help researchers uncover why some people appear to have evaded the pandemic.

In fact, researchers are already working to answer that question.

Their most definitive finding so far: NOVIDs are exceedingly rare.

"There's a difference between people who *believe* they've never had COVID and those who truly haven't," said Dr. Sabrina Assoumou, an infectious disease physician at Boston Medical Center and a researcher at Boston University.

Data suggest only about 2 to 3 percent of people have no COVID antibodies worldwide, COVID, Page A15

'It all seems very last-minute and chaotic.'

OCTAVIANO BORORING, of Dover, N.H., about the process

A trying tryout for Cup volunteers

By Michael Silverman, Chris Serres, and Milton J. Valencia
GLOBE STAFF

Seduced by the chance to be part of soccer history, thousands of New Englanders raised their hands last year to volunteer for this summer's FIFA World Cup in Boston.

Many even waved pom-poms.

But for many the experience has been a baffling conga line of communication breakdowns and bottlenecks, adding to a string of organizational miscues during preparations in Boston for the world's largest sporting event.

With kickoff now only days away, many of the 1,500 volun-

teers who made the cut find themselves confronting unexpected questions. What, exactly, have they signed up for? And were the months of delays and confusion worth it?

"What should have been an awesome, once-in-a-lifetime experience was a frustrating mess," said Diana Correia, a volunteer applicant from Peabody who received her rejection notice on Mother's Day after a six-month wait.

More than a dozen applicants from New England described a cascade of logistical letdowns: canceled training events, rejection emails sent in error, incorrect birth dates that delayed their accreditation, VOLUNTEERS, Page A14

MARCHING WITH PRIDE



FINN GOMEZ FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Thousands of people made their way from Copley Square to Boston Common during the city's 56th annual Pride Parade on Saturday. The theme of this year's parade was "Pride as Protest: Since 1776." B1.

Steaming service

Sunday: Breezy, stormy. High: 81-86. Low: 57-62.
Monday: Sunny, pleasant. High: 69-74. Low: 57-62.

Complete report, **A24**.
Deaths, **A18-22**.

VOL. 309, NO. 158

Suggested retail price
\$6.00



So many options for food, drink, and activities; how can you choose? We offer our list of the Best of the Best. **Globe Magazine**.

The concept of doppelgangers can be found throughout the arts. Critic Chris Vognar asks: Why does the idea continue to terrify us? **N1**.

Once a voice for Platner, she is now a critic from the sidelines

By Sam Brodey and James Pindell
GLOBE STAFF

The moment a random oyster farmer from Down East Maine named Graham Platner announced a run for the US Senate last August, a well-known woman in local politics joined the campaign to give it local credibility and heft.

Since then, Genevieve McDonald — a former state legislator, lobbyist, and trailblazing lobsterman turned political operative — has become a catalytic char-

acter in the dramatic story of Platner's candidacy.

►At Bar Harbor rally, Platner tells Mainers, "You have my back." B2.

Just not, perhaps, in the way the candidate and his team may have expected.

When the first wave of negative headlines dropped for Platner last October, which revealed his offensive online posts and his Nazi symbol tattoo, McDonald, Page A12

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